WKwebview does not allow video being played in the background

Asked 9 months ago Modified 9 months ago Viewed 551 times Part of Mobile Development Collective

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I've been working on a personal iOS project for fun — essentially a YouTube music player, learning how background media playback works in native iOS apps.

After seeing that Musi (a famous music streaming app) can play YouTube audio in the background with the screen off — I got really curious. I've been trying to replicate that basic background audio functionality for YouTube embeds using WKWebView. I've spent a crazy amount of time (probably 20 hours) trying to figure this out but have achieved no success.

Here's what I've tried so far:

-Embedding a YouTube video in a WKWebView

-Activating AVAudioSession with .playback and setting .setActive(true)

-Adding the UIBackgroundModes key with audio in Info.plist

-Adding the NSAppTransportSecurity key to allow arbitrary loads

--Testing on a real device (iPhone 14, iOS 18.1 target)--

What happens:

Audio plays fine in the foreground.

If I exit the app and go to the lock screen quickly enough (less than 3 seconds) after pressing play, I can resume playback briefly from the lock screen — but it doesn't automatically continue like in Musi and other apps like it.

Most of the time, the audio stops when the app is backgrounded.

I get this error consistently in the logs:

Error acquiring assertion: <Error Domain=RBSServiceErrorDomain Code=1 "(originator doesn't have entitlement com.apple.runningboard.assertions.webkit AND originator doesn't have entitlement com.apple.multitasking.systemappassertions)"

It seems like the app lacks some specific entitlements related to WebKit media playback. I don't have AppDelegate/SceneDelegate (using SwiftUI), but can add if needed.

I'm super curious how music streaming apps using youtube as a source get around this — are they doing something different under the hood? A custom player? A SafariViewController trick? Is there a specific way to configure WKWebView to keep playing in the background, or is this a known limitation?

Would really appreciate any insight from folks who've explored this before or know how apps like Musi pulled it off.

Thanks in advance!

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asked Apr 22, 2025 at 0:49
Rapidx
11 2

Firstly test on other video with AVPlayer. It's possible that it's just Youtoube stopping playback in background by itself. – Cy-4AH Apr 22, 2025 at 10:05

iFrame does not allow background audio. – lorem ipsum Apr 22, 2025 at 12:19

I've tried numerous other videos beside just youtube content, and none of them seem to work in the background automatically. I can play a video and then exit the app but the audio will stop playing and I have to manually resume playing from the lock screen or control center. My other theory as to how other apps work around this is by automatically resuming the play state in the player controller whenever the app enters the foreground state. You can notice this when using a browser like VideoLite which seemingly gets paused for a few hundred milliseconds and then resumes automatically. – Rapidx Apr 23, 2025 at 13:18

But I think in Musi's and Demus' case, they resume the content fast enough to where there is no delay or the play command is hit faster than the initial pause command whenever the apps goes to the background. Or they may even intercept the pause signal and continue to always play. But I have yet to test this, if there is any other information or help I would highly appreciate it. – Rapidx Apr 23, 2025 at 13:21

I'm having the same issue, did you find a fix? – joder123 Sep 4, 2025 at 2:03

1 Answer

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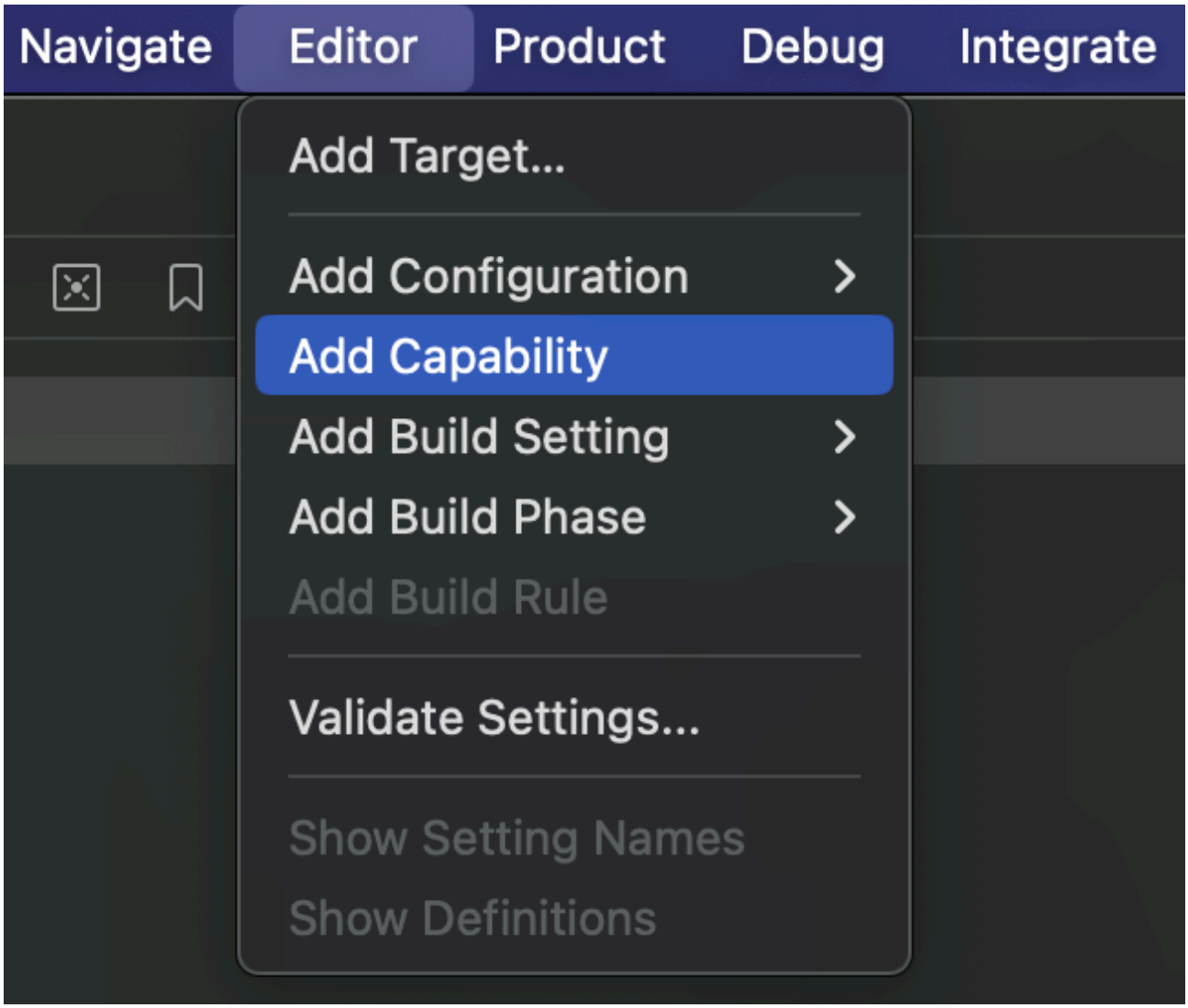
Setting of `AVAudioSession.Category` to `playback` tells the app that "playing recorded music or other sounds that are central to the successful use of your app" and will allow background playback.

Copy

```swift
import SwiftUI
import AVFoundation

@main
struct MyApp: App {

    init() {
        let audioSession = AVAudioSession.sharedInstance()
        do {
            try audioSession.setCategory(AVAudioSession.Category.playback)
        } catch {
            print("Setting category to AVAudioSessionCategoryPlayback failed.")
        }
    }

    var body: some Scene {
        WindowGroup {
            ContentView()
        }
    }
}
```

Additionally, need to add the '*Background Mode*' capability,

Editor->Add Capability, and check '*Audio, AirPlay, and Picture in Picture*'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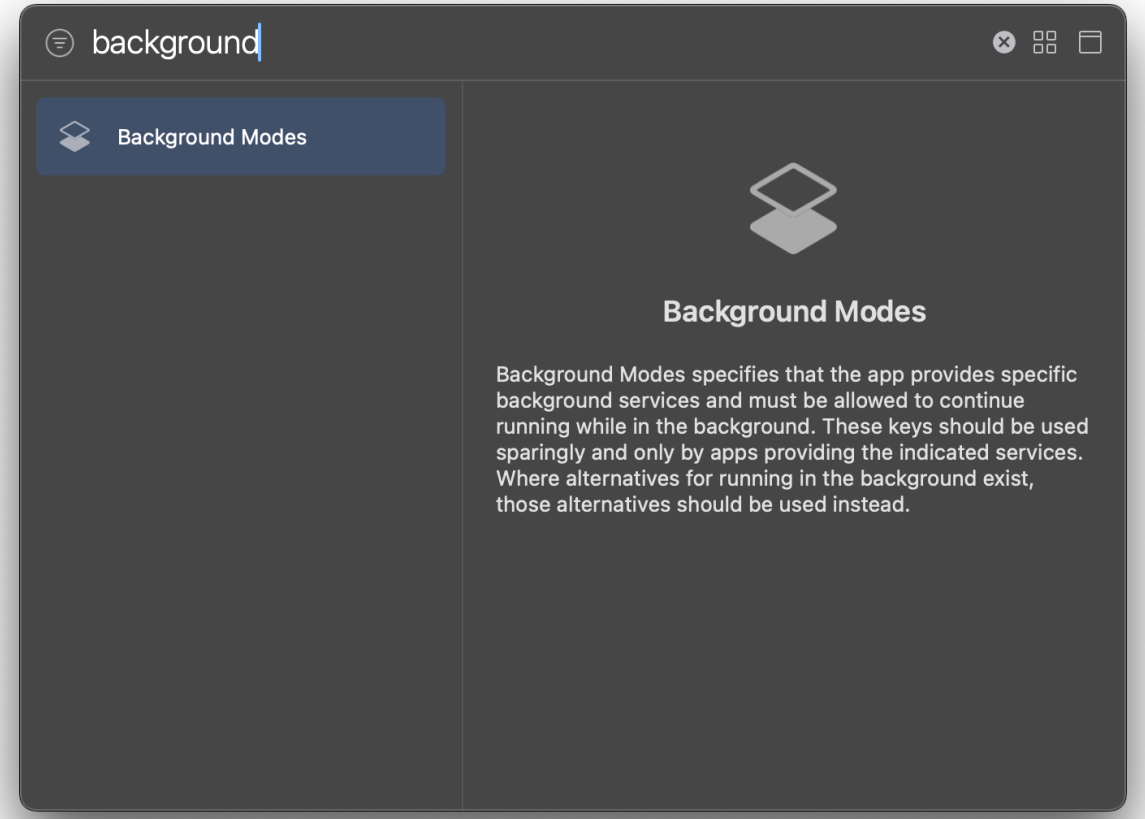

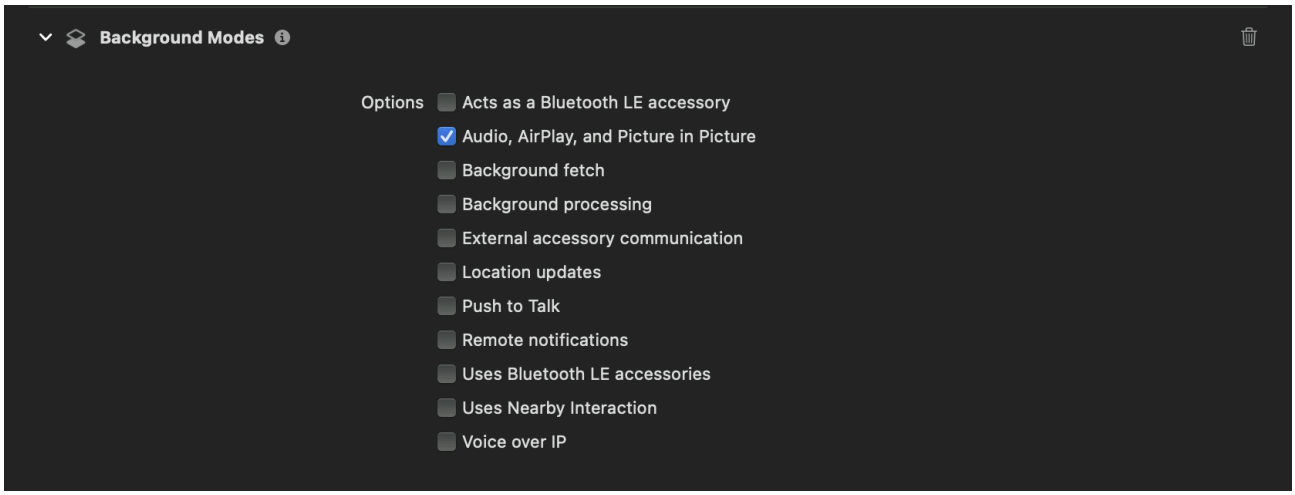

Share Improve this answer Follow edited Apr 25, 2025 at 14:17 answered Apr 23, 2025 at 13:49

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2 Comments

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Rapidx Apr 24, 2025 at 23:45

Thank you for your response, but I currently have something similar implemented but it still does not work. Do you know any other solution or idea as to why background playback on a webview is not working? My current code: do { try AVAudioSession.sharedInstance().setCategory(.playback, mode: .default, options: []) try AVAudioSession.sharedInstance().setActive(true) print("Audio session configured for background playback") } catch { print("Failed to set audio session: (error)") }

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clawesome Apr 25, 2025 at 14:26

Maybe try setting your webview's configuration to allow picture in picture(`webview.configuration.allowsPictureInPictureMediaPlayback = true`) playback? If that doesn't work then you may need to setup an example project in Github that can be tested

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